Automatic Child Support Intermediation in France

Data and Empirical Strategy

Public Economics – Research Proposal

ENSAE – Institut Polytechnique de Paris

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Data: Source, Coverage, and Sample

Dimension	Proposed data and sample
Source	ALLSTAT-FR6: administrative statistical files of CAF beneficiaries, produced by the French National Family Allowance Fund (CNAF); access via CASD subject to approval.
Geography / period	Metropolitan France and, subject to consistent coverage, overseas territories; proposed observation window 2017–2025, with latest years subject to release and access.
Unit of observation	Beneficiary/family case $\times$ month, conditional on the structure of available identifiers and files.
Study population	Single-parent CAF beneficiary households with dependent children; analytical subsample with usable child support information.
Main exclusions	Records without a reliable family identifier, dates or relevant child support measures; sample attrition and non-CAF households explicitly documented.
Access / feasibility	Public documentation exists; research access, exact vintages, longitudinal linking and variable coverage require confirmation.

Source: CASD, ALLSTAT-FR6 catalogue; sample is proposed, not yet extracted.

Data: Sample Construction and Observation Unit

1. **Start from monthly CAF beneficiary records** in available ALLSTAT-FR6 vintages (target: 2017–2025).
2. **Identify single-parent family spells** using recorded household/family composition; distinguish entry into single parenthood from first observation in CAF data.
3. **Recover child support information** and flag observations with usable measures of pension obligations/receipts; document missing and zero values separately.
4. **Build a longitudinal panel** using stable case/beneficiary identifiers, checking changes of allocataire, CAF transfers and family composition.
5. **Define policy cohorts only if feasible:** date of establishment of an enforceable child support order, and type of order; otherwise no order-based treatment indicator.

What does one row represent?

One CAF family case in month t, with observed family composition, child support-related fields, benefit amounts and reported resources.

Selection concern: CAF records do not represent all separated parents; case entry/exit may correlate with outcomes.

Data: Variables and Measurement

Concept	Candidate measures	Interpretation / validation needed
Child support Y_{it}	`MTPADU`, `MTALIMFO`, `MTPALIFT`, `MTALIMVE`	Verify exact dictionary labels, units, periodicity, missing/zero coding and whether amounts are due, declared, fixed or actually received.
Financial security	ASF eligibility/receipt and monthly amount	ASF may compensate for unpaid/low pensions; November 2022 ASF revaluation creates a major confounder.
Other resources	RSA, Prime d'activité, declared household resources	Outcomes may reflect benefit formulas and reporting lags rather than immediate disposable income.
Household controls	Single-parent status, number/age of children, family composition	Potential controls and sample definitions; avoid conditioning on post-treatment changes.
Policy exposure D_i	`NATJUG` (candidate), order date/type if present	`NATJUG` alone must *not* be assumed to identify IFPA participation or an order date.
Timing	Monthly observation; dates of family changes and orders if available	Distinguish administrative recording date, separation date, order date and IFPA start.

Candidate ALLSTAT variables identified in preliminary dictionary review; operational definitions remain to be validated.

Data: Policy Exposure and Measurement Challenges

Institutional variation

March 2022: automatic intermediation for newly fixed child support in judicial divorce proceedings. **January 2023:** extension to other relevant enforceable titles. Existing orders are not automatically equivalent to new orders under these rules.

Needed for causal design	Status in ALLSTAT
Exact order date	Not established; first observed pension is *not* necessarily a newly issued order.
Type of enforceable title	`NATJUG` may help, but meaning and coverage require checking.
Actual IFPA enrollment	No confirmed direct indicator in currently reviewed variables.
Actual monthly payments	Must establish whether recorded pension amounts measure payments or declarations.

Main distinction: policy eligibility, actual IFPA participation and observed child support receipts are not interchangeable.

Methodology: Source of Identification

Methodology: Equation and Estimand

Methodology: Assumptions, Threats, and Feasibility

References and Data Documentation

- **CASD:** ALLSTAT-FR6, *Fichier statistique des allocataires des CAF – données définitives*. `https://www.casd.eu/source/fichier-statistique-des-allocataires-des-caf-donnees-definitives/`
- **CNAF (2024):** *Évaluation du dispositif d'intermédiation financière des pensions alimentaires en phase de généralisation*, Dossier d'étude no. 233.
- **CNAF / DREES (2025):** statistical analysis of the November 2022 ASF revaluation (ALLSTAT-FR6).
- **Rubolino, E.:** *Outlining Data and Methodology*, Public Economics, ENSAE–IP Paris (course slides).

Status

Proposed research design based on public data documentation; no access to individual ALLSTAT records or validated causal sample is claimed.